E-Collar
INTRODUCTION

A Practical Guide to Introducing Your Dog to E-Collar Training the Right Way



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Before We Start

This is a short book with one job. By the end of it, your dog will love the e-collar and will answer a light touch from it the way it answers its own name.

I am going to tell you exactly how I do it. No theory lessons, no long stories. Six steps, done in order, at your dog's pace. Go by your dog, not the calendar. Every dog moves through these steps at its own speed, and that is fine.

Here is the whole idea. Your dog already loves the leash because the leash always comes right before something good. We are going to do the same thing with the e-collar. First the collar itself becomes good news. Then the touch from the collar becomes good news, first at the lightest level and then a little higher. That is all this book does. Think of a hand on your shoulder. A soft touch and a firm one mean different things. The e-collar is the same, and in this book we only use it softly.

We say optional because it is. Some people are not comfortable with these tools, and we understand that. Nobody should ever be made to use one. But I recommend it, and this book will show you why.

What you need

- A Mini Educator ET-300 from E-Collar Technologies. It is the collar I use and the one this book is written around. See Your Mini Educator, next.
- Your dog's favourite treats, cut small.
- Your regular leash and flat collar or harness.
- Ten or fifteen minutes a day.

Get the collar ready

1. Charge the remote and the receiver fully.
2. Read the manual. The touch is the black S button, with the remote in momentary mode (M on the screen). We only use the touch in this book. Leave the T button and the red boost button alone for now.
3. Hold the contact points on your palm and turn the dial up from zero, one level at a time. Notice how faint the first level you can feel is. I test every

collar on myself before it goes on a dog. You should too.

4. Set the dial back to zero.

Fit it right

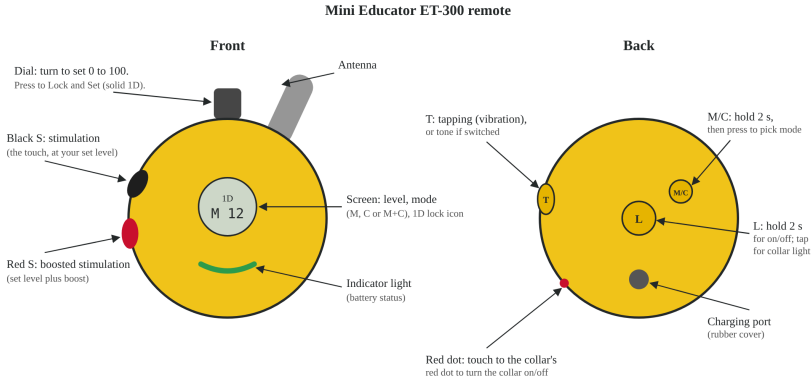
1. The collar sits high on the neck, just below the ears, with the receiver off to one side, not on the windpipe.
2. Both contact points touch skin. On a thick coat, part the hair so they sit down against the skin.
3. Snug, not tight. Two fingers under the strap, and it should not spin when you turn it.
4. The leash always clips to the regular collar or harness, never to the e-collar strap.

Look after the skin

- About eight hours of wear a day is plenty. Never more than twelve.
- Move the receiver to a new spot on the neck every couple of hours.
- Never leave it on overnight, and take it off after swimming until the neck is dry.
- Check the skin before and after every use. If you see redness that does not fade or a sore, leave the collar off until it heals, and see your vet if it does not clear up.

Age. There is no fixed age. Puppy or adult, your dog moves on to each step when it is ready, not when the calendar says so. We never use the collar to correct a puppy, and the low levels in this book are not painful or harmful. Check your manual for fit.

Your Mini Educator



Simplified drawing based on the ET-300/302 Owner's Manual (E-Collar Technologies). Check your own manual.

Why this one. I have tried a lot of collars. The Mini Educator ET-300 is the one I put on my own dogs, and here is why.

- The dial runs from 0 to 100, so you can find the faintest level your dog can feel and move one small step at a time.
- It uses what E-Collar Technologies calls blunt stimulation, which feels more like a muscle tap than a sharp sting.
- It also has tapping (a vibration, like a phone) on its own button, and an adjustable boost of 1 to 60 levels for emergencies.
- It is fully waterproof and reaches about half a mile.
- The remote is the round yellow one. It fits in your palm and you learn the buttons by feel, so your eyes stay on your dog.
- Lock and Set holds your level so a bump on the dial cannot change it.

Charge it. Plug in the remote and the collar. The light is solid red while charging and turns green when full, in about two hours. In use, a blinking green light means the collar is on and ready. Blinking red means it needs a charge. Do not let the batteries run flat, and keep them out of extreme heat and cold.

Turn it on. Remote: hold the L button on the back for two seconds. Collar: touch the small red dot on the remote to the red dot on the collar and hold them together until the light comes on. The same touch turns the collar off.

Pair it, if you ever need to. The two come paired. If you replace a collar: turn the remote on, set the dial to 0, make sure the collar is off, hold the red dots together for more than five seconds until the green light flashes fast, then press the black S and then the red S together for two seconds, until you hear the collar confirm.

Make sure it is on before it goes on the dog.

1. Look for the blinking green light on the collar and a lit screen on the remote.
2. Hold the collar in your palm with both contact points on your skin. Turn the dial up slowly from 0 and press the black S. Most people feel it somewhere between 8 and 25. If you feel nothing, it is off, not paired or flat.
3. Turn the dial back down to your dog's level before the collar goes on.

Lock your level. Set the dial where you want it, then press down on the top of the dial until 1D on the screen stops flashing and stays solid. Solid 1D means locked; turning the dial does nothing. Press the dial again for about a second to unlock (1D flashes). Lock it every time the collar goes on, so a bump in your pocket cannot change it. When you are not using it, the maker advises keeping the level below 5.

Leave the rest for later. The M/C button on the back changes between momentary (one tap per press), continuous and combo modes. Keep it on M for this book. The red S adds your boost on top of your level. We do not use it here.

Fit and skin. Fit it and look after the skin exactly as in Before We Start. The maker's limit is twelve hours of wear a day, and we stay well under it.

Step 1: The Collar Comes Out, Good Things Happen



Why. The first thing your dog learns about the e-collar is how to feel about it. We want that feeling to be pure excitement. When the collar comes out, something good is about to happen. Every time.

How to do it

1. Pick a few things your dog loves: dinner, a game of fetch, a training session with food, a car ride.
2. Right before each one, take the e-collar out where your dog can see it.
3. Let your dog sniff it. Give a treat the moment it does.
4. Put the collar on loosely and start the good thing right away. Dinner goes down, the ball gets thrown.

5. When the fun is done, take the collar off at a calm moment, not as the last thing before the fun stops.

Rules

- Collar first, good thing right after. Never the other way around.
- Never bring the collar out for a bath, a nail trim or a vet visit.
- Never chase your dog to put it on. If your dog is unsure, sit down, let it sniff, give a treat and try again later.

Move on when

Go by your dog, not the calendar.

- Your dog perks up or comes over when the collar comes out.
- Your dog sniffs or noses the collar on its own.

Step 2: The Door Routine



Why. E-collar first, then leash, then the good thing. The leash already means good news to your dog. By putting the e-collar on just before the leash, the collar starts to borrow that good feeling.

How to do it

1. Put two hooks beside the door you use for walks. The leash goes on one, the e-collar on the other. They live there together from now on.
2. Get yourself ready first. Shoes, jacket, treats in your pocket. No delays once the collar goes on.
3. Take the e-collar off the hook and slip it on your dog.
4. Then clip the leash to the regular collar or harness.
5. Open the door and go.
6. When you get home, leash off, then e-collar off, and both go back on their hooks.

Same door, same hooks, same order, every single time.

Move on when

Go by your dog, not the calendar.

- Your dog gets excited when you reach for the e-collar, not just the leash.
- Your dog comes to you, or stands still, to have it put on.
- Some dogs push their head into the collar. That is exactly what we want.

Keep the door routine for life. It never stops working.

Step 3: Wearing It Like Any Other Collar



Why. The goal here is a dog that forgets it is wearing anything at all. If the collar only goes on for training, your dog learns that collar on means rules and collar off means anything goes. We do not want that dog.

How to do it

1. Start snugging the collar to a proper fit before you head out. Treat right after.
2. Leave it on for the whole walk.
3. Leave it on for a while at home afterward: on the couch, chewing a toy, napping.
4. Put it on for meals and play, not only for training.
5. Take it off at random times, not only when the fun ends.

The remote still stays in the drawer. You are not using the touch at all yet.

Move on when

Go by your dog, not the calendar.

- Your dog does not scratch at it or try to rub it off.
- Your dog eats, plays and sleeps normally with it on.
- The skin under the contact points looks healthy.

Step 4: Finding the Lowest Level



Why. In this step we are looking for one thing: the lowest level your dog can just barely feel. The number does not matter. The dog's response does. Watch the dog, not the dial.

How to do it

1. Pick a quiet room. Your dog is calm and has been wearing the fitted collar for a while.
2. Set the dial to zero. Do not ask your dog for anything. Let it relax or sniff around.
3. Tap the touch button once, quickly. Watch your dog.
4. Go up one level and tap again. Leave a few seconds between taps.
5. Keep going until you see the first tiny sign your dog noticed. An ear flick. A turn of the head. A glance at the neck. A blink, or a pause in sniffing.

6. Stop right there. That is your starting level. Give a treat, and end the session.
7. Write the number down. Check it again on another day or two. It should land in about the same place.

If you see more than a tiny sign

If your dog jumps, scratches, yelps or looks worried, you went too far. Drop the dial several levels, give a treat, end the session, and go up more slowly next time.

The level changes with fit, a wet coat and how excited your dog is. Check it each session. Lower is always better.

Move on when

Go by your dog, not the calendar.

- You get about the same level on two or three different days.

Step 5: Pairing the Touch With Treats



Why. This is the step where the touch itself becomes good news. The touch comes first, every time, with no word. The treat comes one second later, every time. Do it enough and your dog hears the touch the same way it hears the treat bag.

How to do it

1. Same quiet room. Dial at your dog's level, or one below.
2. Wait for a calm moment when your dog is not staring at your hands.
3. Tap the touch once.
4. Count one second.
5. Treat from your hand. Say nothing and keep your hands still until after the touch. The touch alone tells your dog a treat is coming.

6. Wait a few seconds. Repeat.
7. About ten repeats is a session. Two or three short sessions a day.

Keep it clean

- Your treat hand stays still until after you press the button. If your hand moves first, your dog learns to watch your hand instead of feeling the touch.
- Never press the button while your dog is eating.
- Change up the gaps between repeats so your dog cannot guess the rhythm.

Now make it come from you

After a few sessions, let your dog wander a few steps away. Tap the touch and wait. Most dogs will turn and look at you, or come straight over. Mark it and pay it well. That is your dog telling you it knows the touch came from you, and that you are where the good stuff is.

Then take it to a second room, the yard, a quiet spot on your walk. Check the level again in each new place. Outside, your dog may need a level or two more. Come back down as soon as you can.

Move on when

Go by your dog, not the calendar.

- Your dog looks at you or comes to you when it feels the touch.
- You see that in at least three different places.
- Your dog is relaxed and happy the whole time.

If your dog seems worried, drop the level, go back to a quiet room, use better treats and shorter sessions. If it is still unsure, come see us.

Step 6: A Little More



Why. In this last step we raise the level a little at a time and keep paying, so your dog's everyday working level sits just above the lightest touch it can feel. We keep the lowest levels free for later, for things like bridging or praising, and your dog's new everyday level can one day be used for off-leash recall. We do not teach either here.

How to do it

1. Once your dog has been lighting up at the lowest level for a good while, go up one or two levels.
2. Pay exactly the same way. Touch, count one second, treat.
3. Stay there until your dog is just as happy, then go up one or two more if you need to. Go by your dog, not the calendar.
4. Check the new level in each place you train, the same as before.

Keep it good news

- If your dog looks unsure at any point, go back down and spend longer there.
- This is still good news, never pressure. Every touch is still paid.
- Now and then, for life, do a few touch then treat sets at the lowest level too, so it never loses its meaning.

What we do not use it for yet

In this book the touch is always followed by something good. Do not use it for barking, chewing, digging, jumping or pulling, and never for anything your dog has not been taught yet. That comes later, and only on a dog that has been conditioned like this first.

You are done when

Go by your dog, not the calendar.

- Your dog brightens up and looks to you every time it feels the touch.
- Your dog is just as happy at its new working level as it was at the lowest level.
- Your dog still pushes its head into the collar at the door.

What Comes Next

Once your dog loves the collar and is happy at its working level, the hard part is done. From here the lowest levels are kept for things like bridging and praising, and the everyday level you just built can one day become your off-leash recall.

That is all in the full e-collar book, E-Collar Training Guide: A Practical Guide to E-Collar Training for the Everyday Pet Dog.

Your dog already loves the leash, because the leash always comes right before something good. This short guide does the same thing with the e-collar. In six simple steps you will teach your dog to get excited when the collar comes out, to wear it like any other collar, and to hear a light touch as good news that comes from you. No corrections, no pressure. Just the foundation every e-collar dog deserves, done the right way from day one.

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